

CHAPTER V

CONDUCT OF LIFE

The Guru's teaching is a beautiful contradiction in the infinite amplitude of his address to man, engrossed as man is in the myriad pursuits of senses. Under an infinite variety of temperaments and choices and compulsions, internal and external environment, man in essence is not visible; it is a mere stomach, or arm, or brain or sex-centre. Flesh, flesh, or excitement of sex or sense, or brain; as Bullah Shah of the Punjab puts it, "It is clay, it is clay, dancing, dancing, reeling, reeling. The bridegroom of clay, the bride of clay, the clothes, clay, clay". All pursuits good or bad, moral as so called, or immoral for the matter of that, or non-moral (unless there is elevation of higher planes of life come to the consciousness of man, and that inspirational elevation comes everywhere) causes, under certain conditions of physical or mental excesses whether of sinful pleasure of meritorious pain, the sickness of soul; different pursuits cause their own characteristic kind of suffocation, even death of the soul.

Men die, despite sensual pleasures and religious vigils. A few rare ones like Omar¹ get life-sparks by a dose of those very poisons. Shiva lives by drinking the poison churned out of the waters of the sea.

True life, to the Guru, is of the soul, not of the body, nor of the mind, which acts when well-fed. The cerebral activity of man is as the light in the tail of the glow-worm, mostly physiological. Will is the expression of the mind, thought of the body, and imagination of the soul. Inspired imagination is the builder of the soul, the raiments of a hundred- coloured light of the soul of imagination are made. The body that the soul wears is made of lightning-flashes. Imagination is the secret of all spiritual progress of man. In fact, it is the substance of all moral and material wealth of man.

What is all this but an imagination of reality? We are made of such stuff as dreams are made on. "From the soul's point of view, therefore, the conduct of life is to be of a wondrously beautiful rotation of moods and of the wondrous variety of the colour of its blossoming. To a true man, if he be man straight and sincere, the Guru addresses himself in different ways. He does not believe for all in one kind of conduct that truly makes a man, the inner moral and spiritual mode which is the real self-manifestation of man, as distinguished from the general restraint of himself for the social goodness and solidarity as a good citizens, as a good and natural servant of society, the inner man with that inner conduct by which a man is what he is to himself and to his God, what he is driven to be, what he is; the inner man with that personal inner quality which stands by him when he is in himself alone what he is in sleep, in soul, in the inner solitudes. To a man of true renunciation and sublime sadness, the Guru might say, better go and be tempted by the beauty of a woman-form, go and marry and live in the self-felicity that is the share of those who live such lives so nobly self-restrained and self—balanced. And at the same time, the Guru tells a selfish, hardened, dried up, all-body-and-no -soul householder—give up all, renounce the sense of property that is killing you, has killed you; give up all, nothing shall accompany you beyond death, O fool, in all this nothing is yours, if you have not gathered your own soul. If you have a home, attune it to the music of the soul and the verities of the infinitude of the soul; distributing all, tormenting no one, breaking no one's heart, all hearts are of God, the Beloved;² feed all, clothe all and be a giver, not a beggar. All hoarders of wealth, and worldly wisdom are the real murderers of the human soul. Less cruel are those who kill the bodies. You kill your soul, how great is your sin." You want to live in this world. If you have to do so, live as the lotus lives in the pond, as the waterfowls live on the lake. ³ Stupor induced by gluttony, sensual pursuits of fleshly pleasures, excitement of nerves and the dusty weary, stolid, humdrum routine as of the blindfolded oil-mill bullock going round and round in an unrelieved meaningless routine is certainly worse than death in your stupid home life of false courtesies, false shows of mosques and temples; then the death of the still more stupid anchorite in the

hapless wildness of his lonely and vain strivings after the divine. Stunning oneself to a nervous calm by starving, or by vigil, or by any other kind of anaesthetizing physiological processes is foolish beyond measure, when the spiritual *peace comes of itself*⁴ in the infinite and natural growth of the life of the soul. And stunning one's finer susceptibilities and impressionability by hard and breathless pursuits of Maya is still worse.

To the king, the Guru says, Be poor. To the poor, Be kings. To those who live to eat, fast, starve; and to those who eat to live he says: Your direction of soul is right, feed yourselves well. Speech to the silent, and silence to the babblers. Avoid the disintegration of your soul occurring by whatever means. To those who are naturally so made as to conserve their energy physical or mental, the Guru says there is true godly rapture for such in a kind of self-spending. To those who are mad after self-spending, the Guru says, the soul becomes but a body, a corpse by burning away its divine substance like that. To those who die of the vow of non—violence and non -injury from within, the Guru says, Go and live on horse-back, sword in hand, and go fighting like the divine knights of God, defending the defenceless, sheltering the shelterless. Foolish is this death in the little hole of a “vow” and a “principle” like a seal: Rise and be heroic on this earth there is nothing so true as to be applicable to all states of life here. Sometimes by injuring, that merit is yours, which is never, yours by the vow of non -injury, for your perfection is yet to be, it is not yours here. To the imperfect, many are the ways that lead to perfection, and therefore no one can say which? And to the perfect, all is becoming. Go, fool of a non-injuring God, your own highest ideal and dream whatever it might be and of whatever kind it might be, will meet you there in the glitter of arms that save the neck of those who were to be tortured to death today, and God will come and kiss you when you lie bleeding there yonder on the battlefield, dying for defending even vainly, fruitlessly the outraged humanity.

If vegetarianism has gone beyond its due horizon of a living feeling and a divine nobleness of love and pity, you might be cured by a dish of meat. To those who are all kitchen, vegetables do cause a self-restraint which shows the path to the ideal humanity, thinking how inhuman it is to kill birds and animals for the man animal.

Society for the solitary is as vitalising as the *drawing- within* of the whole soul and sinking in one's own unknown depths. Prayers and chants suffocate the inmates of temples, while a mere idle loafing on a sunlit bed of white sands in the loneliness of the hill stream banks and idle listening of its meaningless song, is an effective and healing prayer for one who is sickened by the smoke of Society.

Men die of the excess of love and of faithfulness to a particular set of objects of life and love. A courtesan can, at times, therefore, rise to an intensity of soul and spiritual eminence, apparently through her daring confessions of sin, as no ascetic can by his dull, dead routine of good deeds.

The Guru says all else of this and that kind pertains to the accidental and side-growths, or side stuntings of man. Only one thing is needful, that the tree of the human soul should shoot upward along its soul-axis aright, from roots springing in the dark, and raising its tops proudly aloft in the Infinite sunshine of life. There is a subtle balance of soul to which the Guru points out and in that balance everything pertaining to the growth of man, both virtue and vice as dead-weight get proper adjustments. The true moral tendency does not feed the side growths and side stuntings; it identifies itself only with the direction of the soul, with the axis of Creation.

As in the atom of matter, so in the human soul, the balance is life, in which it is weighed. It is an infinite variety of configuration of the so-called positive and negative particles of human qualities of thought and action, of will and imagination, and is in a similar balance of the positive and negative charges. The reality of life in the soul is an inconceivable balance of the imaginary streams of human “doings” forever rushing forward and backward, forever emitting life-forms, making and marking soul-centres.

All what you think and do, your religions, vows and vigils, and principles and systems, and sciences and arts, and schemes of moral uplift of man, aye your pleasures and plunders of freedom of men, women and races — all have a meaning and no meaning at all.

Be full of reverence *here*, for nothing is known, nothing can be known when the “whence” and the “whither” shall forever be unknown. And the “why” of this all shall remain for ever unanswered.

Hence, be full of Awe for this “awful un-nameable”. All is God and all is not God. The variety of human life of body and mind is comprehended, resumed and justified in the life of the soul as the Guru contemplates. On account of this there seems such a constant variation of affirmations in the music of the Guru Granth. In those cosmic storms of song, little consistencies of the worldly kind are as dried leaves being blown hither and thither as of no consequence. These words have no meaning, theories lose all significance only as music rings and makes the soul. God is made manifest by the Guru. His hymns have got one sole significance of shaping man into God.

In his mind, no aspect of human activity is lost, or rendered meaningless by prejudicial emphasis on any one particular aspect of such things and their everunentangled skein, as it usually is lost in the hands of immature inventors of some stray thoughts or overzealous experimentalists who for the first time experience any fraction of the soul-life. Little children are prone to emphasize their own views of creation and truth, for such is the final expression of a child-soul. In the Father, however, all children live with their quivering agility of limbs and with all their mischiefs of thought and action, and all are harmonised and reconciled in the infinite largeness of the Father’s heart. Their activities then have as meaning Creation, and Man finds the meaning of all his systems in the Guru’s soul. The Guru is full of the praise of him who kindles the stars by the light of His heart, from where the Guru sees and says, All is Good. God is good; all is beautiful, for He the Creator is beautiful. The enquiry after the First Cause ceases only in finding the Person of God in the bewildering expanse of the Impersonal, so fascinating grows the universe and this Creation that the very mind dies in the soul—enchancing wonder and in the song of His Praise. The person is discovered as the Beloved, and all complaints and sorrows are cured. The sky finds its beautiful meaning only when it forms the background of a million stars to shine. So call Him what you may, the Unknowable Great Soul of all finds its meaning, here at least under the circumstances and conditions in which life finds itself on this earth, in the souls burning with that very truth, in the shining good men of God. Where to find Him? The Guru says, He is in the shape and voice of the noble and good men. “God lives in the voice of His Saints”.

The true culture of man is of the soul, not of the mind, of feeling, not of thought. Thought is but a physical outgrowth under certain conditions of life and does always die of its own top-heaviness and impossibilities. Feeling is Soul: Thought is but a golden ass put on the throne for certain ceremonial purposes. In proportion as the culture of feeling predominates, man founds a society based on the peace of charity and love and innate nobleness of the human soul, where the individual spontaneously loses his outgrowth of selfishness in the service of his loving brothers and sisters, all, all verily so. In proportion, the culture of thought predominates, the social solidarity vanishes; selfishness poisons man, the soul degenerates into the mere body, a corpse. All religions, arts and literatures get out of their mystic depths of truth and reality, and lose also all the mystic heights of Grace and Beauty of the Formed Human soul. Surely it is not the degeneration of popes and prelates, the mere scum that a soulful society could part aside by the wave of its arm, that led to the Reformation in Europe and the downfall of Roman Christianity, but also the so-called Renaissance in literature in which men like Shakespears became to the mind of the people, greater than teachers of religion. The continuation of the human degradation from the wholeness of the soul, even after the degraded popes had successfully been dethroned, by small men like Luther, is due to an inordinate preference by the people thus induced, for intellectual excitement, for an inordinate restlessness of the senses as

the end all and be-all of life. This culture of thought as started and developed in Europe, has its own beautiful aspects of invention and discovery, but it has ruined the Home of Man, its electric light is insisting like a conqueror to light the tombs. Man's city of life has come to be a dead, mechanical, bizarre scene.

The Guru says, Come out O man! again, imbued with that old deep feeling for the mystery of Creation; for the Presence of the person of God in Nature. Renounce all running after the mirage of sense-desires. Filled with the melodies of soul, like an unfolded blossom on the tree of Truth, live in the spontaneous Rapture of noble kindness of everything. Every step of yours forthwith becomes a miracle, every breath a new discovery of enhancement of love. In short, be souls here, more than bodies. This is all the conduct of life. Look upto Him, the Guru is the Loving Father. He is merciful. All is well if you live looking upto Him. Fear and yet fear not. Nothing is demanded of you but a change of direction. Face the sun and go on. All shadows shall come following, aye flying behind you. Give up the mad chase of shadows, it is insanity.

Footnotes:

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| 1. Omar Khayyam, the hedonist poet is meant. | - Editor. |
| 2. Echo of a sloka of Farid in the holy Granth | - Editor. |
| 3. Echoes of Gurubani. | - Editor. |
| 4. This is the path of Sahj commended in the Sikh faith. | - Editor. |